

PODCAST SCRIPT: "Two Men, One Gospel"

A Speaker Preparation Companion for the Braselton SDA Sermon

Audio Format — Conversational Speaker Walkthrough

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This is a spoken preparation script — written to be recorded as an audio file (podcast or voice memo) that you can listen to while driving, exercising, or walking through the sermon in your head. It is NOT a transcript of the sermon itself. It is a conversation between you and the material, designed to internalize the sermon before delivery.

Approximate recording length: 20–25 minutes. Think of it as: a friend who has read all your notes, walking you through them one last time before you step to the pulpit.

[SECTION 1 — The Heart of the Sermon] ~3 minutes

Alright. Let's talk about this sermon before you preach it.

The whole thing turns on one sentence, and you need to have it in your bones before Sabbath morning: *"Both men stood in the same room, heard the same gospel, served the same apostle, and faced the same world. One drifted. One stayed. The difference was the location of their love."*

That's it. Everything else is expansion and application. If you lose the thread at any point during delivery, come back to that sentence.

Here's what makes this sermon different from a generic "don't backslide" message: it's about *drift*, not rebellion. Demas didn't storm out of the church. He didn't deny Christ in a public forum. He just... moved. Quietly. Incrementally. And by the time Paul names it, Demas is already in Thessalonica and the moment has passed.

That's the hook. That's why this story is dangerous for comfortable, active, present church members — not for people on the margins. Demas was in the inner circle. He had a resume. He had a track record. And he still drifted.

So the first thing you need to settle in your own heart before you preach this: Do you believe this could happen to you? Because if you don't believe it, the congregation will hear it as a message for someone else. And it will bounce off them. You need to preach this as someone who has felt the pull — not as someone reporting on a distant historical case.

We'll come back to the interior turn later. But hold that first.

[SECTION 2 — The Opening Scene] ~2 minutes

Your first job is to put the congregation in the room with Paul. Not with Demas. Not with Luke yet. With Paul.

Rome. AD 67. Second imprisonment. Cold. The man knows he's going to die, and he is writing anyway. He takes attendance.

That scene — that specific, concrete scene — is your on-ramp. Don't warm up to it. Don't start with "good morning, what a beautiful Sabbath." Drop them in. Mid-scene. As if the story has already started and you're catching them up.

Then read 2 Timothy 4:9–11 slowly. Don't comment right away. Let the text breathe. The names in that passage — Demas, Crescens, Titus, Luke — are doing work before you explain anything. The congregation hears a man reading a list. One of the names is missing from where it should be. One name remains.

After you read it, pause. Then: *"Two names. Two men. Same mission field. Same world pulling at both of them. One drifted. One stayed."*

That's your thesis. You've delivered it before the sermon formally begins. Everything after is the argument for something they already feel.

[SECTION 3 — The Biblical Ground] ~4 minutes

Now you walk them through the three Demas appearances. This is where you need to slow down and be precise, because the arc is the argument.

Philemon 1:24 — he's named "fellow laborer." Pause on that. That's not a casual honorific. Paul uses that language for Timothy and Titus. It means inside the tent, trusted, working.

Colossians 4:14 — still present. Named alongside Luke. No warning. No asterisk. This is important because it establishes that the drift was invisible from the outside. His colleagues didn't see it. The congregation at Colossae who read this letter didn't see it. The chronic condition had no visible symptoms yet.

2 Timothy 4:10 — gone. And here is where you spend a moment on the Greek. You don't need to write the Greek on a board or project it — just say it:

"The word Paul uses for 'loved' is agapas — the same word as John 3:16. The same word as the Great Commandment. The word Jesus uses when he asks Peter on the shore: 'Do you love me?' Paul is saying Demas took that word — the word that belongs to God — and gave it to the passing age."

That's the Greek insight. One sentence. Plant it and move on. It will land even with people who don't know any Greek, because they know John 3:16 and they know the Great Commandment.

Then the physician metaphor: **acute versus chronic**. This is your bridge from the biblical evidence to the diagnostic section, and it's where your identity as a physician starts doing theological work. Don't over-explain it — two or three sentences, then the payoff line: *"Demas did not have an acute spiritual event. He had a chronic condition of the soul."*

[SECTION 4 — The Three Diagnoses] ~3 minutes

You have three diagnoses. Keep each one tight — one or two minutes each. They build on each other, so don't rush to the next one before the current one has had time to stick.

Diagnosis 1: Urgency fades to background music. The eschatological urgency that drove Paul — Christ is coming, this world is passing — faded in Demas until it was ambient noise. He stopped feeling that the world was temporary. Ask the question directly: "When did you last feel the urgency you felt the first time the gospel broke through?" Then move. Don't answer it for them. Let it hang.

Diagnosis 2: Good work replaces first love. This is subtle and it's the one that's most dangerous for this congregation. Demas went to Thessalonica, not to sin — to work. The Testimonies Vol. 5 quote lands here: "The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity." Not evil things. *Cares*. Then the staccato line — deliver it slowly, with weight: "The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion. It is comfortable productivity with a cold heart."

Diagnosis 3: The love question. John 21, Peter on the shore. Jesus asking "do you love me?" three times. The question has no substitute — not service, not attendance, not activity. Then pivot to Revelation 2 and the Ephesian church. Active. Doctrinally sound. Persevering. And Christ says: "You left your first love." Ask the congregation: "What would you struggle to surrender if Christ asked for it this week?"

You don't need them to answer out loud. The question does the work internally.

[SECTION 5 — Luke] ~3 minutes

Now the pivot. From diagnosis to hope. From Demas to Luke.

You need to resist the temptation to make Luke a superhero. He is not the dramatic counterpoint to a villain. He is a faithful man who made ordinary choices that, under pressure, turned out to be extraordinary. That's the point. His faithfulness was not a single heroic act — it was the accumulation of daily choices to stay.

Three things that held where Demas's didn't. Practice these so they don't sound like a list:

He wrote himself out of his own narrative. The "we" passages in Acts — Luke is there, present, firsthand — but his name never appears. He had no story to protect. He had given his narrative away. Demas, by contrast, eventually needed his story to go somewhere. Thessalonica served his narrative. Rome no longer did.

He practiced what he documented. He recorded the theology of self-denial — "take up your cross daily" — and then he lived in proximity to a dying man. The integrity between the theology he wrote and the life he chose is the thing that held.

He carried the "only." This is the emotional center of the Luke section. *"Only Luke is with me."* Say it slowly. *Only.* One person's presence became the entire embodiment of the body of Christ in Paul's darkest moment. Luke did not know, when he chose to stay, that this would be the sentence that carried his name through twenty centuries.

You never know when your staying will be someone's only.

Pause there. Let that breathe.

[SECTION 6 — The Interior Turn] ~3 minutes

This is the section you are most likely to shorten under time pressure. Don't.

The interior turn is where the sermon becomes a testimony rather than a lecture. It is where the congregation discovers that you are not preaching at them — you are preaching with them, from inside the same struggle.

Say what is true for you. The pull toward productivity at the expense of presence. The week that was theologically correct and spiritually thin. The version of ministry where Christ has moved from the center of your love to the object of your professional attention. You don't need to manufacture drama. If you've felt this pull — and you have said that you have — just name it simply and honestly.

Then turn it to the congregation: *"The question is not whether you have drifted. The question is whether you are honest enough to stop, this morning, and ask where you are standing right now."*

"Right now" is the key phrase. Not in your testimony. Not in your aspirations. Right now. This Sabbath.

Where is your love?

[SECTION 7 — The Prescription and Close] ~3 minutes

Don't rush the close. It earns its power from everything that came before it.

The Laodicean eyesalve — Spirit-given vision that restores your capacity to see both Christ's beauty and your own need. You can reference this briefly without developing it at length. The congregation knows Laodicea.

Then the three commands from Revelation 2:5. These are the cleanest possible close for this sermon:

Remember — not nostalgia; diagnostic memory. Where were you when the fire was first lit?

Repent — not groveling; turning. *Metanoe* — change of direction.

Return — not to different works but to the first ones. The prayer that was conversation. The Scripture that was nourishment.

Then the final sequence. This is your landing strip:

"You will leave this building today and return to the aīn — the present age. Your phone will notify you. Monday will present itself. And you will make choices. Small ones. Invisible to everyone around you. In aggregate, they are the answer to one question: Which man am I becoming?"

Then: *Steps to Christ*, p. 44 — "duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure." First love produces that. And that is available to you.

Final kicker — deliver it slowly, with space between each line:

"Luke stayed."

"So can you."

"Not in your own strength. In the strength of the One who stayed for you."

"Go love Him first."

Then pray. Briefly. Specifically. Not for success — for reordered love.

[SECTION 8 — Pre-Sermon Checklist] ~2 minutes

Before Sabbath morning, run through this:

Scriptures to have marked — Philemon 1:24; Colossians 4:14; 2 Timothy 4:10–11; Revelation 2:4–5; John 21:15–17. Know which Bible you're using and where these fall.

EGW quotes to have ready — Acts of the Apostles p. 455 (Demas "shortsighted exchange"). Acts of the Apostles p. 490 (Luke's comfort to Paul). Testimonies Vol. 5 p. 161 (absorbed in business). Steps to Christ p. 44 (duty becomes delight). Have the books with you or the quotes written out exactly.

The Greek words to say out loud — practice saying *agapē* (ah-GAH-pay-SAS), *aiōnā* (eye-OH-nah), *monos* (MOH-nos). You only need the first one in the sermon, but know them all.

The four staccato kickers — say these aloud until you can say them without looking at the page:

- "One drifted. One stayed. The difference is the whole sermon."
- "The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion. It is comfortable productivity with a cold heart."
- "You never know when your staying will be someone's only."
- "Luke stayed. So can you. Not in your own strength. In the strength of the One who stayed for you."

The interior turn — decide exactly what you're going to say. Write two or three sentences about a real moment when you felt the pull — the productive week with the thin heart. Don't improvise this section. Know what you're going to say. The congregation needs it to be real, and real requires preparation.

Time check — if you find yourself behind during delivery, compress the three Luke anchors to two (cut "he practiced what he documented" — it's the weakest of the three for a general congregation). Do not compress the interior turn or the close.

[CLOSING NOTE]

This sermon exists because Demas exists — and because Demas is not safely in the first century. He is in this congregation, in recognizable form. He is in you and in me, in the version of us that is productive and present and quietly moving.

The goal is not to frighten anyone into faithfulness. The goal is to make Luke seem possible — not superhuman, but genuinely possible for an ordinary person who has settled the question of love.

You have preached versions of this material before. The Braselton congregation hasn't heard it. Preach it as if you are discovering it alongside them. Because in the ways that matter most, you still are.

Go preach well. Go love Him first.

End of podcast script. Total estimated recording time: 20–25 minutes.